



St. Paul's Cathedral

Christopher Wren's Baroque masterpiece, whose dome has defined London's skyline for more than 300 years

The cathedral of St. Paul's, the seat of the Bishop of London, stands on top of Ludgate Hill, the highest point in the City of London. It is the fifth cathedral to St. Paul to stand on this site. Built by the English architect and polymath Christopher Wren, the cathedral was consecrated for use on December 2, 1697.

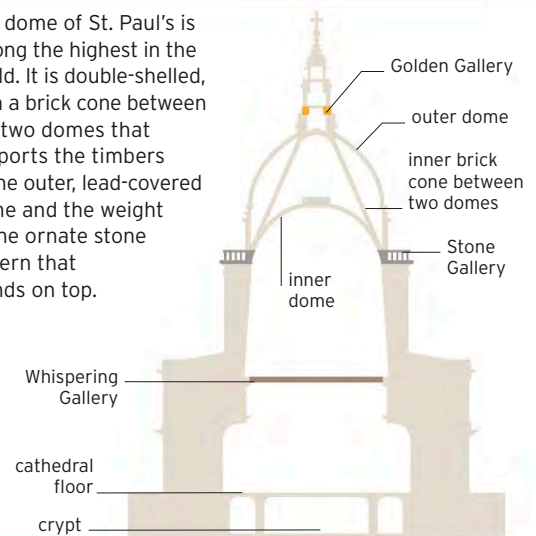
Classical features

Wren's design for St. Paul's needed to satisfy the requirements of the Anglican church and the demands of his royal patron, Charles II. Built in the English Baroque style, with a landmark dome (as on St. Peter's Basilica in Rome; see pp.158–159) and a Classical portico on the west front, the cathedral stands on eight massive piers to support its weight.

The cathedral continues to play a key role in British national life in the modern era. It became a symbol of resistance in World War II, and it was the location of the funeral of Winston Churchill in 1965 and the wedding of Prince Charles to Diana Spencer in 1981.

THE DOME

The dome of St. Paul's is among the highest in the world. It is double-shelled, with a brick cone between the two domes that supports the timbers of the outer, lead-covered dome and the weight of the ornate stone lantern that stands on top.



At **364 ft (111 m) high**, St. Paul's was the **tallest building** in London from **1710 to 1967**

▷ INNER DOME

The dome, painted by James Thornhill (1675/6–1734), features eight scenes from the life of St. Paul with a central oculus, or eye-shaped opening, inspired by the ancient Pantheon (see pp.104–105) in Rome.

◁ STANDING ALONE

Planning laws in the City of London limit the height of new buildings to protect the view of St. Paul's Cathedral from prominent places around the city.

